



What are the different types of evaluation for evaluating whether an organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative 'works'?

An emphasis on doing 'What Works' is today regarded as a key element in the way that organizations should work and in how any initiative should be implemented. This is achieved by performance management and evaluation.

Evaluation is often thought of as only consisting of impact evaluation. This measures whether an initiative has impacted high-level outcomes at its end or when it achieves maturity. The problem with limiting evaluation to just impact evaluation is that if it turns out that the initiative has not improved its outcomes, then the money spent on it has, in a sense, been wasted. It's like the old saying, 'closing the door after the horse has bolted'.

This is why modern evaluation thinking includes a focus on other types of evaluation rather than just limiting itself to impact evaluation. This stems from using a utilization-focused evaluation approach emphasizing delivering actionable evaluation information to multiple stakeholders and decision-makers. Modern evaluation approaches now drawn on: indigenous evaluation - using indigenous values and methods; empowerment evaluation - making sure that disempowered voices are included; developmental evaluation - helping with very early thinking about an initiative; formative and implementation evaluation - optimizing an initiative's implementation; process evaluation - describing the course and context of an initiative; economic evaluation - assessing the costs and benefits of an initiative; and, summative evaluation - providing an assessment of overall worth of an initiative.

This Types of Evaluation Tool (G1) shows each of the components from the DoView Planning Framework (D1) and the types of evaluation associated with each one. Evaluation planners, evaluation commissioners, or evaluators can draw on this tool to work out the specific mix of evaluation types that they want to be used when evaluating an organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative. It can be included in evaluation documentation (e.g. Requests for Proposals, RFPs) to make sure that everyone involved is talking the same language regarding types of evaluation.